

In Search of the Real Monster in Body Horror: Abject and Feminine Grotesque in *The Substance*

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Abstract

The paper titled “In Search of the Real Monster in Body Horror: Abject and Feminine Grotesque in *The Substance*” will analyse how the film discourse employs body horror as a medium to address the societal issue of the commodification of female bodies. This article thematically analyses *The Substance* (2024) as a body horror movie in its projection of the grotesque, from a feminist perspective. Tracing the creation of the grotesque in response to social appearance anxiety, ageism, dichotomous relations of mind and body, and internalised inferiority of the female body that does not pertain to the standard body image of the entertainment industry, the paper attempts to perceive the corporeality of the female body in film discourse. Julia Kristeva’s theory of the abject, Barbara Creed’s conceptualisation of the monstrous feminine, and Mikhail Bakhtin’s theory of the carnivalesque inform the analysis in this paper. Proposing an analysis primarily based on film studies and psychoanalytic literary theory towards the representation of the feminine, the paper elucidates the essential fluidity of the female body.

Keywords: Grotesque, Body horror, Abject, Female, Monstrous feminine